mildly psychotic) ruler of Bukhara then tried to have Dost Mohammad assassinated. ‘The Bukharan Amir secretly instructed the escort that when the party crossed the Oxus they were to scuttle the boat in which Dost Mohammad and the princes were riding and so cause them to drown,’ wrote Fayz Mohammad in the *Siraj ul-Tawarikh*.

> The Afghans were thus taken under guard to the banks of the Oxus and put in boats. A hole was surreptitiously opened in the skiff in which the Amir chose to sit. When the boats moved off, one of the Bukharan Amir’s men who was unaware of his master’s plot sat as the Amir’s escort in the same boat. He planned to cross the river with him and then return. Another man who knew what was going on, spoke to him in Turkish and told him to get out of the boat so that he would not drown with the Amir. But the Amir, whose mother was the daughter of one of the leading Qizilbash of Kabul and was herself a Turk, understood Turkish. When he heard what the man said, he got out of the boat and refused to cross the river. No matter how hard the Bukharan Amir’s people tried to persuade him to get back in and cross he refused and said to his companions, ‘It is better to roll in my own blood than to die by drowning. For to die by the sword’s edge will remain as a reminder of the undeniable injustice of the Amir of Bukhara. But if I were to drown, no one would speak of the ill-treatment which he has shown me, his guest.’[t]

The Amir headed back towards Bukhara with his party, now under guard. ‘But a very severe snowstorm blew up which brought everyone to the brink of death. Many of the younger princes were unable even to talk because of the extreme cold. The Amir ordered his personal servants to each take one of the princes and warm them by breathing heavily on them’ in order to save their lives.

> In short, they limped back to Bukhara, and only reached it after the greatest difficulties. Now even the inadequate stipend which had been allotted the first time was withheld by the Amir of Bukhara. Eventually, some seventy of the group fled . . . Nasrullah Khan learned of their escape and ordered seven thousand cavalry to pursue with orders to cut off their escape and, if the sardars chose to fight, then to shed their blood; if not, then to bring them back in chains. At Chiraghchi, they overtook the sardars, surrounded them, and attacked. While bullets and powder lasted, the Afghans held the Bukharans off and spilled much of their blood. But in the end, when they had exhausted their ammunition, the Bukharans fell upon them and took them prisoner. Afzal Khan and Akbar Khan were both wounded in the fight, while several others were killed and many of the rest sustained serious wounds. The Bukharans carried Dost Mohammad and his men back to their city and at the Amir of Bukhara’s order, threw them all in a dark dungeon.[32]

On 2 November 1839, with the puddles in Kabul bazaars now iced over and frost glinting on the willows beside the Kabul River, Shah Shuja left the